



The English East India Company began trading with Surat, a key center of Indian Ocean trade, in 1608. By 1615, it had ousted the Portuguese.

BY ABOUT 1600, THE POLYNESIAN PEOPLES OF NEW ZEALAND, the Maori, had become progressively better established in their new lands (see 1276–85). Although theirs was still a Stone Age society—and would remain so until the arrival of Europeans and the introduction of metal—it was remarkably well adapted to the new environment. Known as the **Classic Maori phase**, the culture was distinguished by elaborate wood carving, precisely patterned bone tools and weapons, and substantial earthwork settlements.

The establishment, with royal approval, on December 31, 1600 of the **English East India Company** was a clear statement of English intent that Spain and Portugal could not expect exclusive domination of trade with

Maori weapon

The wahaika, a short wooden club held by a dog-skin thong looped around the thumb and wrist, was used for close combat.



East Asia. That said, from the start the East India Company was a speculative venture at best. It depended not merely on an uncertain ability to reach these distant lands but, once there, to present itself—militarily and diplomatically—as a credible alternative to its European rivals. It called for a combination of seamanship, commercial intuition, and force—the last a permanent necessity. Eventually, it would establish itself almost as an arm of the English, later the British, state. But it was never intended as a means of conquest or colonization—**enrichment for its shareholders was its sole goal**. Ironically, its penetration of these new markets coincided with that of another latecomer, the Dutch. European domination for the riches of the East Indies would be contested not between England and Iberia but between England and the Dutch.

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CUBIC MILES
THE VOLUME OF
MATERIAL
EJECTED FROM
HUAYNAPUTINA
VOLCANO, PERU



Tokugawa Ieyasu was 60 years old when he received the title of shogun from Emperor Go-Yōzei. He remained the effective ruler of Japan until his death.

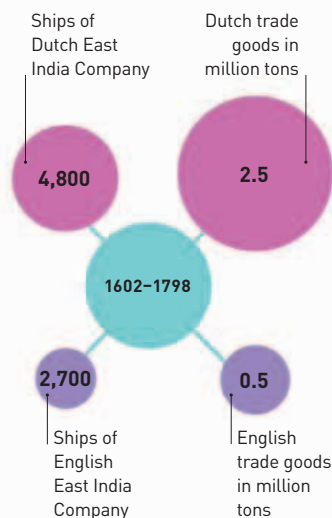
FOR AROUND 100 YEARS, THE DUTCH EAST INDIA COMPANY, established in 1602 and exact equivalent of its English rival, was the **most successful commercial venture in the world**. Its

navigators not only outflanked the Portuguese in the Indian Ocean—pioneering new routes deep into the Southern Ocean as a means of access to the East Indies—but, having reached their lucrative goals, they exploited them with a single-mindedness that left their predecessors floundering. In 1602, the Dutch had laid claim to Guiana in South America. More importantly, by 1605 they had ousted the Portuguese from the Moluccas (Spice Islands). The foundations of a Dutch East Asian trading empire had been laid.

When **James I** (1566–1625) became **King of England** in 1603 on the death of Elizabeth I, he had already been **King of Scotland**, as James VI, for 36 years. Although they remained two quite clearly separate countries, sharing only a common monarch, James did manage to drive through the repeal of mutually hostile laws. Otherwise, the closest he came to the union he sought was an Anglo-Scots flag, the **Union Jack**, known for his preferred French name, Jacques.

On the very same day as James's accession, **Tokugawa Ieyasu** (1543–1616) became **shogun** of the Tokugawa shogunate of **Japan**. He presided over a rigidly stratified, inward-looking society that endured for 250 years.

French exploration in the New World was resumed by **Samuel de Champlain** in 1603. Over the following 12 years, he made a series of pioneering journeys along the St. Lawrence River toward the Great Lakes. In 1605, he also established a short-lived French colony, Port Royal, in Nova Scotia and, in 1608, a **permanent French base at Québec**. Although partly motivated by a search for a river passage to the Pacific, Champlain recognized that this rugged land was valuable in itself, above all for its **furs**. He subsequently sponsored a series of westward explorations beyond the Great Lakes, championing the potential of *Nouvelle France*.



Trade in East Asia
The Dutch East India Company was five times as successful as its English equivalent throughout the 17th and 18th centuries.



Guy Fawkes (third from the right) and his fellow Catholic conspirators.

“ THE SPANISH ASSAILED THE UNASSAILABLE; THE DUTCH DEFENDED THE INDEFENSIBLE. ”

Anonymous, Siege of Ostend

WHEN SPANISH FORCES UNDER GENERAL SPINOLA TOOK OSTEND from a combined Anglo-Dutch force on September 16, 1604, it **ended a siege** that had lasted three years, two months, and 17 days. Even by the standards of 17th-century Europe—a century that saw only four years of peace—it was an extraordinarily brutal business. Siege warfare developed in response to artillery, to which the medieval castle, with high, thin walls, was vulnerable. Instead, fortifications became lower, thicker, and very much larger. So much so that many fortified towns were beyond the range of contemporary guns, and a blockade was the only practical means of taking them.

The **death of Czar Boris Godunov** in 1605 brought to a head a **political crisis** rapidly engulfing Russia, one heightened by a terrible **famine** that killed two million people—a **third of the population**—in 1601–03. Hoping to exploit Russia's divisions to its own advantage, and supported by disaffected Russian nobles, an unofficial **Polish-Lithuanian force** had already invaded the

